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DAILY EDITORIAL SUMMARY

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The Chambal Sand Mining Crisis

GS Paper II: Government Policies and Interventions for Development in Various Sectors and issues arising out of their Design and Implementation

Context:

Recently, the **Supreme Court of India** took **Suo Motu** (on its own motion) cognisance of rampant **illegal sand mining** in the National Chambal Gharial Sanctuary, noting **lawlessness** and the mafia's **"superior firepower"**, and gave **MP, Rajasthan, and UP** a **one-month deadline**, warning of **paramilitary deployment**.

Ecological and Hydrological Significance:

The **Chambal River** is a unique ecosystem where sand plays a dual role in maintaining environmental balance:

- **Biodiversity Anchor:** The river is the primary habitat for the **Critically Endangered Gharial**. Sandbanks are essential for their nesting and basking; excessive exploitation leads to total **Habitat Loss**.
- **Hydrological Sponge:** River sand acts as a natural sponge, allowing water to percolate and **Recharge Groundwater Aquifers**. Its removal leads to the collapse of these aquifers and significantly increases **Flood Risks**.
- **Slow Replenishment:** Unlike other minerals, river sand takes geological ages to replenish, making current extraction rates **Ecologically Unsustainable**.

The Organized Illegal Nexus:

The crisis is driven by an underground economy estimated at **500 Crore Rupees**, sustained by a deep-seated **Politician-Bureaucrat-Criminal Nexus**.

- **Institutional Helplessness:** The "sand mafia" is reportedly better armed than forest officials, leading to **Brutal Murders** of forest guards, such as the recent killings of **Harikesh Gurjar** and **Jitendra Singh Shekhawat**.
- **Economic Drivers:** High urban demand for river sand—due to its **Superior Bonding** with concrete compared to alternatives—makes the trade immensely profitable.
- **Infrastructure Risk:** Mining around foundational pillars has left a critical bridge on **National Highway 44** at risk of collapse, with pits reaching depths of **30 to 50 feet**.

Mandatory Judicial Directives (2026):

The **Supreme Court** has outlined a **Technological and Inter-State Firewall** to be implemented by **May 11**:

- **Technological Surveillance:** Mandated installation of **High-Resolution CCTV (Closed-Circuit Television)** cameras and **GPS (Global Positioning System)** devices on all mining trucks. Real-time data must be fed directly to the **Police** and **District Magistrates**.
- **Integrated Machinery:** To prevent criminals from exploiting **Jurisdictional Loopholes** (fleeing across state borders), the Court ordered an **Integrated Machinery** with **Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs)** for joint patrolling.
- **Legal Accountability:** Immediate seizure of machinery and **Disciplinary Action** against any official found in **Tacit Connivance** or delaying enforcement.

Legal and Institutional Framework:

While the framework for protection is robust on paper, ground-level implementation remains the weak link:

- **MMDR Act:** Under the **Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act**, sand is classified as a **Minor Mineral**, placing the primary onus of regulation on **State Governments**.
- **Environment Protection Act, 1986:** Provides the legal basis for protecting **Ecologically Fragile Zones**.
- **Sustainable Sand Mining Guidelines 2016:** Issued by the **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change** to promote regulated mining, yet largely ignored by the mafia.

Way Forward:

The Court emphasized that **Short-Term Gains** and greed cannot bypass the **Rule of Law**.

- **Promoting M-Sand: Manufactured Sand (M-Sand)**, produced by crushing stones, is a sustainable alternative. The government must address the **Perception Problem** regarding its cost and bonding quality.
- **Advanced Technology:** Utilizing **ISRO (Indian Space Research Organisation)** satellite imagery and **Drones** to provide a bird's-eye view of illegal operations.
- **Circular Economy:** Encouraging the **Recycling of Construction and Demolition (C&D) Waste** to reduce the pressure on river basins.
- **River Basin Authority:** Establishing a dedicated authority for the **Chambal River** to ensure a unified conservation strategy across the three states.

Conclusion:

The Court's intervention reaffirms **environmental protection as part of the rule of law**; the threat of **paramilitary deployment** signals **administrative failure**, and restoring Chambal requires **strong institutional will** to dismantle the **mining nexus** and prioritise **ecological sustainability**.

Mains Practice

Q. Illegal sand mining is not merely an environmental hazard but a governance failure fuelled by a political–bureaucratic–criminal nexus. Critically examine. What institutional measures are required for sustainable minor mineral management? (250 Words, 15 Marks)

Costs and Wages: On the Noida Labour Unrest

GS Paper III: Indian Economy and Issues related to Planning, Mobilisation of Resources, growth, Development and Employment

Context:

Recent unrest in Noida reflects **deep economic distress**, where **labour discontent** over **wages, job security, and working conditions** has escalated into **violent clashes and disruptions**. It signals a **fracturing of the social contract** among the **State, industry, and workers**, highlighting **governance and regulatory gaps**.

Primary Triggers- Wage Disparity and Inflation:

The mobilization was sparked by a sharp comparison with neighboring **Haryana**, which increased **Minimum Wages** by **35%** following similar unrest.

- **The 21% Gap:** The **Uttar Pradesh Government's** offered interim hike of **21%** was viewed as insufficient by workers demanding a monthly salary increase to a range of **18,000 to 25,000 Rupees**.
- **The Cost of Living Crisis:** Stagnant wages have collided with high inflation. Workers reportedly spend **one-sixth of their income** solely on **LPG (Liquefied Petroleum Gas)** and food, making a **dignified life** under **Article 21** nearly impossible to sustain.

Concerns with the New Labour Codes (2025):

The consolidation of **29 Central Labour Laws** into **Four Labour Codes** (**Wage**, **Industrial Relations**, **Social Security**, and **Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions**) is at the heart of the dispute:

- **The Wage Floor Institutional Failure:** Under the **Code on Wages**, the **Central Government** is mandated to set a legally binding **Wage Floor**.
  - Its failure to do so has allowed **States** to keep wages artificially low to compete for industrial investment.
- **Extension of Working Hours:** The latest codes facilitate a shift from the standard **8-hour workday** to a **12-14 hour** shift.
  - Protesters allege this is often done without the legally required **Overtime Payment**.
- **Erosion of Collective Bargaining:** The rights to form **Labour Unions** and hold strikes have been restricted, effectively turning labor rights into "paper tigers."

Informalization of the Formal Sector:

A critical structural shift highlighted by the protests is the **Rising Trend of Contractualization**:

- **Job Insecurity:** Approximately **40% of the workforce** in the formal manufacturing sector now works on a **Contractual Basis**, leading to a total loss of job security and statutory benefits.
- **The Share of Contract Labour:** This is the highest share of contract labor since 1997-98, as the **New Labour Codes** encourage companies to avoid long-term employment commitments.

The Institutional Void:

The breakdown in industrial peace is attributed to the absence of dialogue:

- **Indian Labour Conference (ILC):** This essential **Tripartite Body** (Government, Employers, and Employees) has not convened since **2015**.
- **Lack of Consultation:** The **Labour Codes** were passed without the tripartite consultation that the **ILC** would have facilitated, leading to a complete **Institutional Void** in policy-making.

Way Forward for Labour Welfare:

To restore industrial harmony, the following steps are essential:

- **Enforcing Humane Shifts:** Reverting to a mandatory **8-hour workday** and ensuring strict enforcement of **Overtime Pay**.
- **Inflation-Indexed Wages:** Ensuring timely wage increments that keep pace with the rising cost of **Food** and **Fuel**.
- **Reviving the ILC:** Re-institutionalizing the **Indian Labour Conference** to include worker representatives in policy decisions.
- **Implementing the Wage Floor:** The **Central Government** must immediately set a national **Wage Floor** to prevent a "race to the bottom" among states.
- **Fixed Leave Policies:** Meeting the demand for fixed working hours and a minimum of **four paid Sundays** a month.

Conclusion:

The Noida protests expose **fault lines in the New Labour Codes**, where **ease of doing business** risks overriding the **right to livelihood and dignity**. Sustainable reform demands **institutional dialogue** and must prevent the **formal sector from driving informalisation**.

Mains Practice

Q. The recent wave of industrial strikes exposes the vulnerability of contract labour under the new Labour Codes framework. Critically evaluate the balance between 'Ease of Doing Business' and 'Worker Welfare' in India.

(250 Words, 15 Marks)

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